

EXAMEN INGLÉS PAU JULIO 2018

Option A: Women really are the stronger sex

A recent academic study has shown that under extreme conditions such as famines, epidemics and enslavement, women are able to survive for longer than men. Across modern populations, women outlive men in almost all instances, with life expectancy for English women being 83.1 years, compared to 79.5 years for men.

Now, academics from the Southern University of Denmark have looked at data from seven historic cases when populations were exposed to extreme hardship, in order to gain new insights into the gender mortality gap. Case studies included the Irish famine of 1845–1849, the Iceland measles epidemics of 1846 and 1882, and the experiences of freed Liberian slaves returning to Africa from the US in the early 19th century. During the 1882 Iceland measles epidemic, for example, life expectancy dropped from 43.99 to 18.83 years for females and from 37.62 to just 16.76 years for males.

The researchers found that women had lower mortality across almost all ages, and women lived longer on average than men. Based on these findings, the academics concluded, "the hypothesis that the survival advantage of women has fundamental biological underpinnings is supported by the fact that under very harsh conditions females survive better than males even at infant ages when behavioral and social differences may be minimal or favor males". The academics referred to research that suggests hormonal differences might explain the gender mortality gap. For example, estrogens, found in larger quantities in women, have anti-inflammatory effects, whereas testosterone, found in larger amounts in men, may actually suppress the immune system.

Excerpt from an article by Tomasz Frymorgen, BBC.co.uk, January 10th 2018

Part I. Reading Comprehension

1. Are the following statements true (T) or false (F)? Identify the part of the text that supports your answer by copying the exact passage on the answer sheet. (2 points: 0.5 each)

- Women outlive men only under extreme conditions.
- Women have always lived longer than men except during the 1882 Iceland measles epidemic.
- Hormones do not explain differences in life expectancy.
- Biological differences alone fully explain why women live longer than men.

A2. Answer the following questions using your own words but taking into account the information in the text. (2.5 points: 1.25 point each)

- Under what severe circumstances do females live longer than males?
- Why do women live, biologically, longer than men?

A3. Find a synonym for each of the four words below from these six options. All words are underlined in the text (1 point: 0.25 each)

	outlive	hardship	measles	survival	underpinnings	harsh
a. <u>severe</u>				b. <u>difficulty</u>		
c. <u>foundations</u>				d. <u>survive</u>		

A4. Choose a, b, or c, in each question below. Only one choice is correct. (1.5 points: 0.5 each)

1. Danish researchers have found relevant data about life expectancy using...

- data from Southern Denmark.
- 19th century data.
- large amounts of hormones at infant ages.
- present-day genetic research methods.

2. Research from 1845 until 1882 took into account...

- three different samples.
- four different samples.
- five different samples.
- epidemics and slavery from various centuries.

3. Males do not live longer than females...

- but they did in the past.
- but they outlived females in Iceland.
- even if social conditions are better for males rather than for females.
- because testosterone increases immunity at all ages.

Part II. Composition (130 to 150 words approximately) (3 points)

5. Choose one of these two topics and write a composition about it.

- A) What would you do to live longer?
- B) Describe your experience and point of view about gender differences in health or life expectancy.

Option b: Major brands of bottled water contain tiny particles of plastic

In the largest investigation of its kind, 250 bottles bought in nine different countries were examined. Research led by journalism organisation Orb Media discovered an average of 10 plastic particles per litre, each larger than the width of a human hair.

Companies whose brands were tested told the BBC that their bottling plants were operated to the highest standards. The tests were conducted at the State University of New York in Fredonia. Sherri Mason, a professor of chemistry at the university, conducted the analysis and told BBC News: "We found plastic in bottle after bottle and brand after brand. It's not about pointing fingers at particular brands; it's really showing that this is everywhere, that plastic has become such a pervasive material in our society, and it's pervading water –all of these products that we consume at a very basic level".

Currently, there is no evidence that ingesting very small pieces of plastic can cause harm, but understanding the potential implications is an active area of science. Commenting on the results, Prof Mason said: "It's not catastrophic, the numbers that we're seeing, but it is concerning".

Experts have told the BBC that people in developing countries where tap water may be polluted should continue to drink water from plastic bottles. Furthermore, the companies behind the brands have insisted that their products meet the highest standards for safety and quality. They also point to the absence of any regulations on microplastics and of the lack of standardised methods of testing for them.

Adapted from an article by David Shukman, BBC News Science, March 15th 2018

Part I. Reading Comprehension

1. Are the following statements true (T) or false (F)? Identify the part of the text that supports your answer by copying the exact passage on the answer sheet. (2 points: 0.5 each)

- a. Researchers examined bottles of water from an average of 10 countries.
- b. The presence of plastic particles in bottles is rare.
- c. People in developing countries should only drink tap water.
- d. There are currently no standardised procedures for testing microplastics in bottled water.

A2. Answer the following questions using your own words but taking into account the information in the text. (2.5 points: 1.25 point each)

- a. What did companies say when the BBC told them about the findings from this study?
- b. Have researchers shown that these plastic particles are bad for people's health?

A3. Find a synonym for each of the four words below from these six options. All words are underlined in the text (1 point: 0.25 each)

	investigation	pervasive	concerning	meet point	testing
a. worrying			b. research		
c. fulfill			d. omnipresent		

A4. Choose a, b, or c, in each question below. Only one choice is correct. (1.5 points: 0.5 each)

1. Research led by Orb Media found out that microplastics in bottles of water were...

- a. wider than a human hair.
- b. as wide as a human hair.
- c. also contained human hair.
- d. only present in a few selected brands.

2. The analysis of water bottles was conducted by...

- a. a university professor working for BBC News.
- b. a professor from a university in the state of New York.
- c. a university professor of chemistry working for the BBC.
- d. a team of BBC journalists and university chemists in Europe.

3. Water companies highlight...

- a. the lack of standards in the plastic industry.
- b. the lack of clear regulations on the presence of particles of plastic.
- c. the lack of standardised tests for plastic industries.
- d. the danger of drinking tap water instead of bottled water.

Part B. Composition (130 to 150 words approximately) (3 points) Plastic is polluting our world.

- A) What can we do to stop it?
- B) Describe your experience and point of view about the information you receive regarding the safety and quality of everyday products, such as bottled water. How much do you trust this information, and how do you decide what sources to believe?

